

MANDAR DEODHAR

> THE INTENTION OF 'HEALTHY FLIRTING' IS TO CONNECT AND BE COMFORTABLE.... **IT IS ESSENTIAL TO HAVE A GOOD RELATIONSHIP** WITH YOURSELF. 'COUNSELLING' COMES WITH A TABOO ATTACHED; 'COACHING' IS A MORE RELAXED WORD"
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> **– PRATIK JAIN,** *Men's dating coach, Mumbai*

decisions is missing," says Dr Sameer Malhotra, psychiatrist at Delhi's Max Hospital, Saket.

CONQUERING ONE'S FEARS

According to dating experts, more men than women battle emotional difficulties. Yadhuvir Singh is a men's dating coach and runs a 'Seduction Lab' on Facebook, where he dispenses dating advice. "Most men are preconditioned by Bollywood to think they have to protect women, woo them with gifts, and only after that should they express their inner feelings," says Singh. He tries to get clients to focus on communication as early as possible. "They might have men's bodies, but are still boys in their heads—they don't know how to channel their emotions into words," he says. Singh gets them to open up by conveying what women really want. "The modern girl can provide for and protect herself. What she needs is an emotionally stable partner." Regardless of clients' needs—relationship, sex or marriage—they all go through a behaviour-modification process with him.

Fresh from the hands of a dating coach, Akshay Bhasin (name changed), a senior HR manager at a Gurugram-based international bank, says his belief in women and love altered drastically after he went through a process of "emotional man-tangling"—a reckoning with his skein of emotional attitudes and responses. "I thought women wanted to be nurtured, but my past dates said I was overprotective, I 'mansplained' (being condescending to women) and I was sexist. It hurt, because I didn't know how I was being any of these things," says Bhasin. Now, he is able to distinguish between caring for his partner and intruding into her personal freedom. Instead of deciding what to eat, who should pay and when to meet, he allows decisions to be made mutually. He still finds it difficult to speak his heart out, but he feels his dates can sense his good intentions.

There is a quiverful of other skills for men to learn. Pratik Jain, a Mumbai-based men's dating coach, teaches 'good flirting', among other things. "The intention is to connect and be comfortable," he says. In recent years, he and other coaches have seen a surge in clientele as people have less inhibition about relationship counselling. "I think 'counselling' comes with a taboo attached, but 'coaching' is a more relaxed word," says Jain. He also emphasises on being emotionally desirable. "It is essential to have a good relationship with yourself, and then with others," Jain says, adding that the most common problem he sees is fear—of appearing vulnerable, needy or coming across as a creep—or an emotional block. Unless they break through those fears, says Jain, people will not attract a well-matched partner.

Dating experts say that they would like clients to "learn and practice relationship skills" before things go wrong. "So that we can prevent, rather than treat issues. This would save a lot of heartache and emotional upheaval," says Kulkarni. Basic training for a healthy relationship involve how to "build self-awareness, practice listening to one's partner, building rituals of connection and learning ways of dealing with conflict". Sandeep Varma, 19, a student in Mumbai, has taken such training. He says watching his friends suffer made him want to improve his personality before looking for a partner. "I couldn't say no to people. I learned how to have a boundary and now know that creating comfortable spaces is not being selfish but being self-caring. This has improved my friendships," he says.

Of course, there is no guarantee that coaching will miraculously offer up a perfect match. It eventually comes down to an individual's capacity to absorb and judiciously apply what they learn, which can still be limited by deeper psychological blocks. But what a dating coach does is get one off the blocks—a starting point to discover oneself through the process of finding an ideal partner. ■